Extensive Commentary on The Song of Glorious Vajradhara, a Praise of the Blessed One

Śīvajradharasaṃgītabhagavatistotraṭīkā · Toh 1163 · Derge Tengyur
བཅོམ་ལྡན་འདས་ལ་བསྔོ་བ་དཔལ་རདོ་རྗེ་འཆང་བདེ་གཤེགས་གཅིག་པུ་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

The Extensive Commentary on The Song of Glorious Vajradhara, a Praise of the Blessed One, known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Vajradhara Saṃgīta Bhagavati Stotra Ṭīkā and in Tibetan as Chomdendé la Töpa Pal Dorjé Dzin gyi Yang kyi Gyacher Shepa, is Toh 1163 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra). It is a close commentary on a short hymn to the buddhas, which it reads as both a praise and a supplication for the supreme accomplishment, explaining phrase by phrase how the buddhas' Dharma body is pure suchness, how compassion has become their very nature, and how their activity for beings never ceases, even when they display nirvāṇa. Along the way it answers objections, such as whether boundless space can serve as an equal example for the buddhas, and whether compassion, being conceptual, can belong to beings free of every stain. Its colophon attributes the work to the learned master Śāntarakṣita and records that it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Vidyākaraprabha and the editor-translator Paltsek.

In the language of India: śī vajradhara saṃgīta bhagavati stotra ṭīkā. In the language of Tibet: Extensive Commentary on The Song of Glorious Vajradhara, a Praise of the Blessed One.

Homage to Mañjunātha (Mañjuśrī).

The one whom the wise, with their intellect and words,
can find no way to praise that bears the fruit they wish,
the noble Mañjughoṣa, whose qualities are like the sky,
boundless and pure: to him I always bow.

The praise that begins, "Possessing the supreme dharma, unequaled, unmoving sameness," is also, in the main, a supplication, for at its close it says in praise, "Grant me the supreme accomplishment of the three pledges of all!"

And who are those whom it is fitting to beseech for the supreme accomplishment? They are those who are themselves completely pure in nature, who are under the sway of great love, who bring about the two fruits of love, and who possess the qualities that accord with these. Those whose nature is impure cannot benefit even themselves. Even those who are

completely pure in nature, if they lack great compassion, accomplish no great and wondrous benefit for others, like the solitary buddhas (pratyekabuddhas). And even if they possess great compassion, if, being powerless because they lack the qualities that accord with its fruits, they do not bring about the fruits of love, namely removing harm and accomplishing benefit, then they are not fit objects of supplication; for people of sense who are pinned beneath a rock do not appeal to the lame, the blind, and the like to pull them out.

Therefore, to make known that they are completely pure in nature, it says, "Possessing the supreme dharma, unequaled, unmoving sameness." To show that love has become their very nature, it says, "whose nature is compassion." To express that they bring about the two fruits of compassion, it says, "dispelling the suffering of beings," and "granting the accomplishment of all qualities, without equal or end." To show clearly that they possess the qualities that accord with the two fruits of love, it says, "stainless, unmoving, unequaled, the finest of supreme dharmas." This is the condensed meaning.

The analysis of the words is as follows. It is unequaled and it is also unmoving, so it is "unequaled and unmoving." It is unequaled and unmoving and it is also sameness, so it is called "unequaled, unmoving sameness." Sameness of this kind is itself the supreme dharma, and those in whom it is present are so called. This teaches the very Dharma body (dharmakāya) of the Tathāgatas, which is suchness.

Here, it is unequaled because, free of all adventitious stains, it has reached the culmination of purity and so is beyond compare: it is equal and comparable to no one, or nothing at all is equal or similar to it, and so it is "unequaled." This explains suchness as completely and unerringly pure.

"Moving" means becoming otherwise. Because there is no moving, it is "unmoving": the meaning is that at all times it never departs from the utterly pure, nondual nature of reality. This explains it as perfected, because it is unchanging.

Sameness is the nature of what is equal: no entity whatsoever passes beyond the intrinsic nature that is emptiness. Therefore, by this nature, all phenomena are of one taste in emptiness, and equal. It is both supreme and a dharma, hence "supreme dharma." Since it is to be known through reasoning and through clear scripture, suchness is not divorced from reasoning. How so? Because it holds the very absence of the characteristics of the known and the knower; and because it holds this, it is also a dharma. Alternatively, "supreme

dharma" means the supreme among dharmas: when it is cultivated in meditation, it brings the perfection of abandoning all obscurations and also brings about the attainment of the riches of every quality without exception.

Again, one may ask: if emptiness pervades all the multitudes of sentient beings as well, why is it called the Dharma body of the Tathāgatas alone? It is because, being utterly pure, it is manifest only in their mindstreams. In others it is veiled by obscurations and not manifest, and so it is as if absent.

Those who have compassion as their very self, that is, as their essential nature, are those "whose nature is compassion." In them it has become thoroughly natural through devoted cultivation over many incalculable eons.

"Of beings" means "of the world." "Suffering" is suffering of any kind; in brief, its nature is the five aggregates of clinging. Those whose way is to dispel and cast it off are so called, because through the meditation they teach, suffering is turned back without remainder.

"Equal" means likeness. "End" means a final limit. All the qualities there are, such as the powers and the factors of awakening, have neither equal nor end, and so they are "without equal or end." "Accomplishment" means perfection. The words are construed as "those whose way is to grant it," and this is connected with "to beings." The sense is that they grant those qualities of a Tathāgata that are incomparable and each immeasurable; for by earnestly applying oneself to what they have taught, one attains the state of a Sugata, which benefits all beings. For this very reason, some read, "granting the accomplishment of all qualities, inexhaustible." Others read, "granting the accomplishment of all qualities, equal and unequaled." This shows only the highest way of accomplishing benefit, since that is presented as something accomplished with no need for any further effort; but they do also bestow other benefits, such as the state of a universal monarch, whose nature is exalted status.

The words beginning "stainless, unmoving" form a compound of attributes: those who possess such dharmas as the analytical knowledges (pratisaṃvid), which are the excellent causes of benefiting others, are so called. Of these, "stainless" is said because they are endowed with purity in every respect. "Unmoving" is said because by their nature they never decline, or because they remain for as long as saṃsāra lasts. "Unequaled" is said because, as before, they are beyond compare. "Supreme" means foremost: the supramundane dharmas, those of the buddhas and others. The best of these

dharmas is "the finest of the supreme"; since they are unshared, this is explained as "the foremost even among the foremost."

Alternatively, it means those who have the finest, supreme object, because they focus on the utterly pure sphere of reality (dharmadhātu); and they are, by their very nature, the self-awareness of it. Others say that "supreme" means what is to be sought, and that it is "finest" because it surpasses all.

Here, the sentence in brief is: "Sugatas such as these, grant me the supreme accomplishment!" These two verses alone, the first and the last, set forth the real content of the intended meaning, whole and complete. The other three verses besides these serve to dispel spurious objections.

Here the spurious objection is this: How can sameness, and dharmas such as the analytical knowledges, be unequaled? For there is something equal to them: space, which is completely pure by its intrinsic nature and immeasurable, and that very thing has been made their example. As the Tathāgataguhya Sūtra says:

All those, however many,
who make comparisons for the qualities of the buddhas,
since they fall short of the Buddha,
do nothing but disparage the Guide.
Here the one thing that serves as an example,
the one equal to the qualities of the buddhas,
is taught to be the element of space,
which has no limit anywhere at all.
As vast as space may be,
the Sage's moral discipline, concentration, and wisdom,
his gnosis, liberation, and vision of gnosis
are declared to be exactly as vast.

Therefore, the objection goes, their being beyond compare is not established. Because of this objection, it says the passage beginning, "Space does not have the status of an equal example."

"Space" is simply space. Even if one wishes to speak of it as an example, the point is its status as an equal example for the Blessed Ones. Things that are examples by being equal are "equal examples," and their nature is "the status of an equal example." If even that is lacking, how could it have the status of a superior example? Its status as an inferior example is not denied.

What, then, is space like? "It is not comparable even to a fraction of a minute portion of the qualities." "A portion of the qualities" means a small part of them. The "minute" part of that is an exceedingly minute part. And a "fraction" of that again is a part beyond which even the intellect can take nothing further away. The "portion" of all the qualities present in the state of buddhahood is any one quality whatever, such as greatness or inexhaustibility. Its "minute" part is the qualities present at the causal stage that produces it, those included in the ten grounds. And a "fraction" of that is every arising of the awakening mind that is included in the practice through conviction (adhimukticaryā). Space is neither comparable nor similar even to that fraction, and this is the cause of its lacking the status of an equal example.

If one asks how space is not comparable even to that: it is because the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are "always granting supreme accomplishment to the element of sentient beings." "The element of sentient beings" means their whole multitude. To it they grant supreme accomplishment. "Supreme" means the qualities such as the powers and the factors of awakening, and their "accomplishment" is their perfection. Those whose way is to grant this to each according to their fortune are so called. In the Tantra of the Gathering of All Buddhas, the line appears as: "clearly bringing about supreme accomplishment for the element of sentient beings." There, the meaning is: those whose way is to bring it about that the element of sentient beings, each according to their fortune, is illuminated and pervaded by supreme accomplishment.

If one asks why they are like this: it is because they "possess accomplishment without equal or end." Since they have the perfection of their own qualities, unequaled and endless, they bring about in others too a fruit that accords exactly with their own. Therefore they are "beyond example." An example is applied to the thing it illustrates by corresponding to the quality present in that thing which one wishes to express, as it is explained:

If an example is at odds
in place, in time, in action, or the like,
whatever likeness the illustrated thing
bears to the example: that is the example.

Here the intention is to declare the Blessed Ones beyond compare because they grant the accomplishment of all qualities, without equal or end. If the qualities of the Blessed One were something with parts, then, since each and

every part of them would always be granting supreme accomplishment to the element of sentient beings, what need is there even to mention the qualities present at the stages of cause and result, in their entirety, taken together? Space, or anything else whatever, though immeasurable, does not possess a property by which it could become an example for the Blessed One. Rather, it is with a view to their being alike merely in immeasurability that the sūtra says:

Here the one thing that serves as an example,
the one equal to the qualities of the buddhas,
is taught to be the element of space,
which has no limit anywhere at all.

It speaks thus of a likeness to space only to that extent.

Another spurious objection: If the masters of the three worlds are those whose nature is compassion, then how can they possess stainless dharmas? Compassion, the wish that sentient beings be free from suffering, is conceptual by nature, so if they possess it, stainlessness is out of the question. For this very reason it is called compassion (karuṇā), because it obstructs happiness. Moreover, since all conceptual thought operates by clinging to its own image as something external, it is erroneous by its intrinsic nature alone: it is ignorance. Because of this objection, it says here the passage beginning, "Ever stainless, arisen from the force of compassion."

"Ever stainless" means always free of stain, and it is construed with "the fulfilled aspiration." "The force of compassion" is its unbroken succession, its arising without interruption. "Arisen from it" means having truly arisen from it. "Aspiration" is the wish made in the mind at the stage of a bodhisattva: "May I attain buddhahood for the benefit of beings!" Its fulfillment is the fruit, which is omniscience. If one asks what such a thing is: it is "the unceasing nature of reality." That intrinsic nature, the nature of reality, in which there is no ceasing, that is, no break in continuity, is the "unceasing nature of reality." The fulfilled aspiration that has this unceasing nature of reality is so called.

If one asks what the fruit of that fulfilled aspiration is, it says the passage beginning, "of beings." "The benefit of beings" is their welfare: the attainment of the two happy destinies, and the reversal of all the suffering of beings. "Accomplishing" it means achieving it. "Making it their chief concern" means being intent upon it. If one asks whether it is something whose bounds are fixed, each separately, by place and time: no, it is "boundless."

The places and times in which they act for the benefit of beings are boundless and leave nothing out, and what possesses this is so called. Those who have great compassion as their self, meaning their essential nature or their cause, are so called. One such as this always appears in manifold forms and is beautiful, by sending forth nets of light rays of manifold emanations and so forth. "Always" is said by way of illustration; it should be understood to mean "in all directions" as well. In the Gathering of All Buddhas, the line appears as, "The compassion of the great-souled always appears in manifold forms." There, this very phrase, "arisen from the force of compassion," is a summing up. Those who possess greatness of self, in that, though they do not conceptualize, they never interrupt their benefiting of others, are so called.

Here, the real point of the condensed meaning is this. The compassion present at the stage of a bodhisattva, which is conceptual and is in essence the wish to protect all sentient beings completely from suffering, is what propels omniscience, which is free of the entire net of conceptual thought. Therefore, either as a figurative designation that does not distinguish cause and result, or because the word "self" is a synonym of "cause," they are called "those whose very self is compassion." Alternatively, because that very conceptual compassion has been habituated through supreme meditation, as a result it comes to arise without any conceptual thought of sentient beings, just as happens through habituation to desire, grief, and the like. That compassion of theirs has no object of reference, is ultimate because it is unerring, arises of its own accord, and has become natural to them; and so they are also called "those whose very self is compassion." It is also called "compassion" in keeping with the name of the earlier factor that propels it.

In that state, since it is free of all signs, it is not the domain of any words. Yet, since it will not do to leave it unspoken, what is said here serves only to show that there is a certain dharma which, though it does not conceptualize, acts for the benefit of all beings everywhere, in every place and time without exception, and turns the wheel of Dharma: a dharma surpassing even the king of precious wish-fulfilling jewels.

On this very point there is a spurious objection: How can this fulfilled aspiration have the unceasing nature of reality? How can the boundless compassion of the great-souled ones always appear in manifold forms? For when the Protectors pass into final nirvāṇa, all of this too is cut off, with nothing carrying on. To this, it says the passage beginning, "Its cessation does not come about."

"Ceasing" means being cut off, and "cessation" is the state of ceasing. "Come about" means "go," that is, it means "come to be." If one asks what it is that does not cease: it is "the activity of compassion," that is, of both kinds of compassion. "Activity" means its operation, and that is omniscience itself. If one asks why it does not cease: it is because it is "unmoving." The meaning is that, since the Blessed Ones have attained the nonabiding nirvāṇa, it continues for as long as saṃsāra lasts. That being so, after displaying nirvāṇa in one world system, they display birth and so forth elsewhere.

If one asks what it is like: "to the three worlds" means to all three worlds. "Supreme" means the qualities of a buddha and so forth. "Accomplishment" means perfection, and the activity grants it. If one asks in whom it does not come to cease: "in the immeasurable ones, who do not measure." Those whose multitude of qualities is wholly immeasurable, with no limit set to it as "just this much," are "the immeasurable ones": the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. They also "do not measure": those immeasurable ones themselves do not gauge one another, thinking, "These possess this much excellence of qualities." In those who do not measure in this way, it never comes to be cut off.

"Even when they have gone to the abode of bliss, the state that is perfectly complete": the state in which there is perfect completion and culmination is "perfectly complete." It is the occasion on which they display the nirvāṇa in which no aggregates remain. Here, too, it is the condition for their own aim. That very state is "the abode of bliss," because in it there is the activity of benefiting others. For by displaying nirvāṇa, they tame those who take pride in displaying their bodies and their possessions, by arousing in them a thorough disenchantment. And since this, that even those who have passed into nirvāṇa never interrupt their activity, produces the greatest wonder in those unaccustomed to the way of the Great Vehicle, it says, in keeping with their way of thinking, "How wonderful! Excellent is the nature of reality!" The nature of reality of the Tathāgatas, their intrinsic nature, is "excellent" because it is utterly marvelous. For those whose disposition has become that of the Great Vehicle, the wonder is not great, because there is no passing into nirvāṇa.

In some versions, "the abode of bliss" does not appear; but there the meter becomes deficient. Or else, since there is no fixed rule, one should not cling to what is designated by convention, as it is said:

Designation arises from convention,
and that in turn arises from the speaker's wish;
it is made for the sake of common usage,
like the names of the parts in prosody and grammar.

Then it says the passage beginning, "When beseeched, they grant the supreme." Because they grant sentient beings the supreme fruit they wish for, according to their fortune, they "grant the supreme." This, too, is a reason to beseech them: thoughtful people ask only of those who give, not of those who are miserly, even though they have wealth.

If one asks how the Blessed Ones possess wealth, it says, "Through supremacy in giving, they have found supremacy of state." "Giving" means all the perfections, since in essence they are the giving of material things, of fearlessness, and of the Dharma. Those whose giving is supreme, utterly pure through the complete purity of the three spheres, are "supreme in giving," and their nature is "supremacy in giving." Those who have a supreme state, whether lordship, or rank, or realization, are "supreme in state": the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Their nature is "supremacy of state," and that is omniscience itself, the buddha ground Samantaprabhā. Supremacy of state through supremacy in giving: that is "through supremacy in giving, supremacy of state."

"Have found" means that they have attained it by bringing it about as their very nature. The meaning is that they possess buddhahood, accomplished through its cause, the completely pure accumulation of gnosis. Alternatively, it is "supreme giving" because they give the supreme as a gift to sentient beings. Thus it is the condition for their own aim. Through it, supremacy of state arose: that is, they possess that rank, accomplished solely by benefiting others.

Moreover, since speaking only in general terms of "giving the supreme" could lead one to think them on a par with Brahmā and the others, who give no more than paltry boons, it qualifies this with the words, "Always granting the sublime to the three worlds, accomplishing the supreme": that is, to those of the three worlds. Because they bring about the supreme fruit and cause it to be accomplished, they are "accomplishing the supreme." Among the lords of the tenth ground, who grant the sublime, those who accomplish the supreme are the ones "granting the sublime, accomplishing the supreme." In the Gathering of All Buddhas the line reads, "granting the supreme

accomplishment"; there it should be explained as granting the accomplishment, that is, the perfection, of the supreme, the qualities of a buddha.

They are "Sugatas" because they have gone into perfect peace, irreversibly and completely. Those who possess a knowing mind unobstructed with regard to the three times are so called; the meaning is that they see the past, the future, and the present with unobstructed gnosis. And if one asks why this is so: it is because they are "free of obscurations." Obscurations are what block and obscure, namely, those called the afflictive obscurations and the obscurations to the knowable. Those in whom these are absent because they have abandoned them are "free of obscurations." This is the fruit of being a Sugata.

In some versions "Protector" appears, not "Sugata." There the meter is broken, and the reply to this is the same as before. "Protector" means the lord of the three worlds.

"Of all" refers to those who dwell in the boundless world systems of the ten directions.

In the passage beginning "of the three pledges, the supreme," the words "the three pledges" mean: "Grant it to me, who am devoted to the Tantra of the Three Pledges"; or, "Grant me the supreme accomplishment taught in it"; or, "Grant me the cause of realizing it." The tantra in which the three pledges appear, that is, the three commitments, whose nature is faith in the Buddha, the Dharma, and the irreversible Saṅgha, is the Tantra of the Three Pledges. Alternatively, the three pledges are these:

For the sake of accomplishing every aim,
never giving up the awakening mind,
being steadfast in the observances of the Sage,
and practicing the search for knowledge of reality.

As this very tantra says of those who are fit for the practice:

One whose awakening mind is firm,
whose intellect has become free of attachment:
for such a one this will surely be accomplished;
one should have no doubt of it.

The supreme among all mundane and supramundane excellences is the excellence of omniscience. Alternatively, it is the supreme accomplishment

among all accomplishments, such as becoming a spell-holder (vidyādhara) or a universal monarch; and that is omniscience itself. Its "accomplishment" is its perfection, that is, bringing it about so that it can be directly realized; and the meaning is, "Grant this to me swiftly!"

This king of praises, spoken by the Lord of Secret Mantra:
by whatever vast merit I have gained from explaining it,
may sentient beings swiftly, relying on Mañjuvara (Mañjuśrī),
become fit vessels for praise such as this.

This completes the Extensive Commentary on The Song of Glorious Vajradhara, a Praise of the Blessed One, composed by the greatly learned master Śāntarakṣita, who relies on the dust of the lotus feet of noble Mañjuvara.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Vidyākaraprabha and the chief editor-translator, the monk Paltsek.

Translator's Notes

• The commentator reads the praise as addressed to the buddhas collectively and analyzes its first line as a possessive compound, "possessing the supreme dharma that is unequaled, unmoving sameness"; the quoted lines of the praise are rendered to fit his analysis.
In the homage verse, □□□□□□□□ ("Gentle Speech") is taken as the name Mañjughoṣa, that is, Mañjuśrī, to whom the opening homage is made.
□□□□□□ is rendered "love"; the commentator uses it interchangeably with compassion (□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□□□).
"Perfected, because it is unchanging" reflects the Yogācāra perfected nature (pariniṣpanna), described as both unchanging and unerring; the preceding gloss of "unequaled" as unerring purity seems to draw on the same pair.
□□□□□ here is the mental continuum (saṃtāna), rendered "mindstreams," not tantra.
The first variant reading of the third line, □□□□□□□□□

and the phrase is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□. In this piece that expression is rendered "those whose very self is compassion" (earlier "whose nature is compassion") so that the commentator's gloss of "self" as a synonym of "cause" can be followed.
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "propels," as in the sentence that follows; □□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "in that state"; and in the quoted verse □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□.
□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is awkward as written; it is taken to mean that no place or time is excluded.
□□ is translated as written, "take pride in displaying their bodies and their possessions"; a reading □□□□□□□□ would give "presume their bodies and possessions to be lasting," which suits the display of nirvāṇa well.
The comparison with habituation to desire and grief echoes Dharmakīrti's argument that compassion, cultivated again and again, becomes natural.
• The Sanskrit vara, meaning both "supreme" and "boon," underlies the second reading of "supreme giving" as giving the supreme, and the contrast with Brahmā, who grants paltry boons.
□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□, "benefiting others"; as written it would mean "benefiting the state," which makes no sense here.
The analysis of "granting the sublime, accomplishing the supreme" in terms of the lords of the tenth ground is compressed, and its construal is uncertain.
The Tantra of the Three Pledges is translated by meaning; it has not been identified with confidence.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.